# Historical Sources and Commodity Circulation in the Western Himalayan Salt Economy

## 2.1 Introduction

The movement of salt through the Western Himalayas connected sites of production with pastoral settlements, agricultural villages, trading centres and institutions of government. These connections were maintained through journeys whose organisation depended on seasonal access, transport animals, commercial partnerships and permission to enter particular territories. Salt's history consequently extends beyond the extraction and sale of a material. It concerns the arrangements that made circulation possible and the changes that redirected goods, labour and income across the region.

Chapter 1 established the theoretical and historiographical foundations for examining exchange, customary obligations and political intervention. This chapter turns to the historical record. Its purpose is to examine what documentary sources reveal about commodity circuits and their regulation, providing the evidentiary foundation for the computational reconstruction developed in Chapter 3. The central proposition remains open to investigation: whether salt routes supported wider commercial connections sufficiently to constitute a structural backbone of multi-commodity exchange. The existence of salt trade alone does not settle that question.

Ladakh and Rupshu form the geographical centre of the inquiry, while Garhwal, Mandi and Kinnaur provide comparative cases. These locations reveal different aspects of circulation: seasonal frontier commerce, administered production, and the changing relationship between cross-border trade and local livelihoods. Their comparison does not presume a uniform Himalayan economy. It asks how similar activities, including carrying salt, obtaining grain and regulating access, were organised under different historical conditions.

The emphasis falls on the twentieth century, with earlier treaties and descriptions used to establish relevant precedents. Within that century, colonial revenue arrangements must be distinguished from subsequent border restrictions and changes in transport. The chapter first evaluates the documentary record, then examines commodity circulation and political regulation. It concludes by identifying the problem posed by dispersed historical evidence and explaining why a relational reconstruction is useful. The technical procedures for building and evaluating that reconstruction remain the subject of the following chapter.

## 2.2 The Documentary Record and Its Limits

The historical record is uneven because the institutions and individuals who produced it asked different questions. A district officer sought information about production and revenue; a traveller described places encountered along an itinerary; a village survey investigated households and

occupations. A treaty recorded recognised claims and obligations. These materials become useful together when their perspectives are retained. Reading them comparatively allows a relationship visible in one document to be examined from another position, rather than treating every surviving statement as an equivalent observation.

Gazetteers provide a particularly important foundation. Their accounts gather geographical, economic and administrative information within the boundaries of a district or state. Walton's British Garhwal distinguishes commerce with Tibet, commerce with southern markets and trade within the district (Walton, 1910, p. 42). The arrangement is administratively convenient, but a commodity can move across all three categories. Reading across the gazetteer's divisions is therefore necessary to understand circulation. Imports recorded at a frontier post may enter a sequence of exchanges extending far beyond the place at which they were counted.

The Mandi gazetteer offers a different concentration of evidence. Its discussion of salt includes quarry management, labour, charges and the distribution of revenue between authorities (Emerson, 1920, pp. 160–164). Such detail allows the historian to examine the mechanisms of administration. It also reflects the concerns of the compiling institution: output, efficiency and receipts receive sustained attention. Statements that workers prospered under a revised arrangement should be read as official assessments, alongside the evidence concerning wages and obligations, rather than accepted as comprehensive accounts of workers' experience.

Gazetteers can also contain several historical layers. The date of publication does not date every arrangement described. A volume may reproduce an earlier settlement report, recount a sequence of agreements, and then describe conditions at compilation. Separating these layers is necessary before reconstructing change. The distinction is especially important when a nineteenth-century rule appears beside a twentieth-century assessment of its effects. Otherwise, a retrospective account can be mistaken for a description of one simultaneous administrative system.

Travel accounts organise information differently. Thomson's description of the salt lake identified as Thogji Chumo appears within his account of a journey through the Western Himalayas and Tibet (Thomson, 1852, Chapter VI, pp. 170–174). The itinerary situates observations within a sequence of movement, offering information about the landscape and its accessibility. Its evidentiary reach remains linked to the journey. An encounter with a salt source does not establish the destination of its entire output, just as a description of a caravan does not identify all the exchanges through which its goods subsequently passed.

Treaties preserve the terms through which authorities sought to organise relationships. The reproduced Tingmosgang agreement is relevant to commercial privilege and political obligation, but a provision records an authorised arrangement rather than its uninterrupted enforcement. Translation and republication also mediate access to the text. Administrative correspondence can help establish how provisions were interpreted, challenged or modified, although a complaint and an official response represent situated positions. The distinction between a proposed measure, an accepted obligation and an enforced practice is essential to interpreting political authority.

The village surveys associated with the 1961 Census introduce another scale of observation. Kanum's survey includes a return visit in October 1964, enabling the investigator to compare conditions with earlier visits. Its account brings named traders, household resources and occupational changes into view (Singh, 1965, Appendix XI, pp. 112–115). This is especially valuable where broad accounts of declining frontier commerce leave the consequences for particular households unspecified. The survey's observations must nevertheless be dated individually: material collected during a revisit should not be assigned automatically to the census year printed in the series title.

The surveys also carry a language of development that requires scrutiny. The Nachar volume presents roads and government institutions as forces transforming a previously remote village, while acknowledging earlier seasonal journeys and attendance at Lavi (Singh, 1966, p. 54). The tension is revealing. Remoteness from a motor road did not mean absence of external relationships. A historian can use the report's observations about new connections while questioning a narrative in which meaningful contact began only with modern transport. This permits older forms of mobility to remain visible within an account of subsequent change.

Ethnographic research supplies evidence about practices and interpretations that official accounts often compress. Ahmed's study of Rupshu combines observation with recollections of earlier trade, making it necessary to distinguish what participants remembered from what the researcher witnessed (Ahmed, 1999). Such work is particularly useful for investigating how communities understood changes in access and livelihood. It should not be treated as a timeless inventory of custom. An institution documented late in the twentieth century may preserve an older arrangement, modify it, or have emerged in response to a recent disruption.

The sources therefore support comparison at several scales without producing a continuous statistical record. Trade returns, household cases and descriptions of a fair cannot simply be added together. They measure or describe different activities. Repeated statements may also descend from one earlier account, so repetition across publications is not necessarily independent corroboration. The approach adopted here is to identify what each source establishes, connect related observations, and retain differences in date, location and perspective. This provides a historical basis for reconstructing circuits without assuming that the archive captures every participant or transaction.

## 2.3 Salt within Regional Commodity Circuits

Salt's place in a regional economy depended on the movements that connected its supply with demand. A productive site could be distant from the households that consumed its output, while those carrying salt required food, animals and access to exchange partners. The commodity consequently entered arrangements extending beyond its own sale. Following these arrangements reveals how production and circulation interacted: the return from a journey might take the form of grain, money or other goods needed to sustain the household and prepare another journey.

Walton's account provides a detailed early twentieth-century example. Trade through Mana and Niti depended on passes whose opening and closure followed the seasonal snow. Merchandise travelled chiefly on sheep and goats, with other pack animals also used. Within the accessible season, some traders could undertake several journeys (Walton, 1910, p. 42). These conditions made a route a recurring activity rather than a permanently available channel. The opportunity to trade depended upon coordinating departure, transport and return within a limited interval, with consequences for how many exchanges a household could undertake.

The animals were integral to this timing. Walton notes that the practice of allowing them substantial time to graze restricted the distance covered each day (Walton, 1910, p. 45). Transport capacity was therefore connected to pastoral management. Increasing the length or frequency of a journey could not be considered solely in terms of a merchant's willingness to travel. The needs of the flock also shaped movement. This helps explain why the geographical distance between markets is insufficient for reconstructing the practical organisation of a trading circuit.

The goods moving through these routes were varied. Walton identifies salt and borax among imports and grain among the principal exports, alongside wool, cloth and numerous other products. Salt and borax were commonly exchanged for grain, whereas other transactions could involve cash or piece-goods (Walton, 1910, p. 44). Different forms of payment thus coexisted within the same commercial setting. Barter cannot be treated as evidence of an economy without calculation, nor can the presence of currency establish that social obligations had ceased to organise exchange.

The trading partnership provides a more precise view of those obligations. Each Bhotia trader, in Walton's account, had a recognised Tibetan correspondent or mitra. Within the Niti valley, the partners were expected to deal with one another, and breaches could be subject to sanction (Walton, 1910, p. 44). The partnership linked commercial opportunity to an enduring relationship. It could provide a recognised channel for exchange while restricting the choice of alternative partners. The historical significance lies in this combination of access and obligation, rather than in assuming that customary relationships were necessarily equal or free of conflict.

Frontier traders were not the only people involved in salt's onward movement. Walton describes villagers obtaining or borrowing flocks to trade between the passes and their own neighbourhoods. Salt received for grain was then distributed through upper Garhwal (Walton, 1910, p. 44). This distinguishes crossing the frontier from participating in the commodity's circulation. People without direct access to Tibet could still connect highland imports with local consumers. It also identifies a practical condition of participation: access to transport animals could matter even when the trader did not own the flock.

As winter approached, a further phase began. Merchandise moved south, with temporary camps and depots established along the route. Goods were sold in neighbouring villages, and what remained could reach Kotdwara or Ramnagar. Further journeys were sometimes necessary to dispose of stocks left behind (Walton, 1910, pp. 44–45). Storage was therefore part of circulation rather than a pause outside it. A consignment could be divided between

destinations and sold at different times, making its journey more complex than a single movement from a Tibetan market to a plains town.

The same account records the carriage of grain or plains salt uphill on return journeys (Walton, 1910, p. 44). Direction was not fixed by an abstract division between mountain producers and lowland consumers. Traders could participate in competing supply streams, and a route used to distribute Tibetan salt could also facilitate the arrival of an alternative. This creates a distinction between the persistence of transport connections and the persistence of a particular commodity's dominance. A commercial corridor might remain active while the origin or composition of its goods changed.

Rupshu introduces an important chronological variation. Ahmed places the turn towards Tso Kar as a major salt source after the disruption of access to Tibet in the early 1960s. Earlier journeys obtained salt from Tibetan lakes for onward exchange, including exchange for barley in Zanskar (Ahmed, 1999, pp. 32–33). Tso Kar should therefore be examined within a history of changing supply rather than presented as the unchanged origin of every Rupshu salt circuit. The distinction directs attention to adaptation: continuity in trading activity could coexist with a substantial alteration in where the traded commodity was obtained.

The Kanum survey brings household participation into sharper focus. In its account of the 1964 revisit, it reports that only ten or twelve of the village's 113 families had engaged in trade with Tibet. Their exchanges included salt, wool, pashm, livestock and food products, with Rampur serving as a place of purchase and subsequent sale (Singh, 1965, p. 113). The figures qualify any description of the village as a homogeneous trading community. Direct participation was concentrated among a minority, although the wider consequences of imported goods and commercial activity could extend beyond those households.

Access to capital helps explain that concentration. The survey associates trade with households possessing resources and describes occasional borrowing from moneylenders or obtaining goods on credit from Rampur merchants. Credit from the latter could carry an obligation to sell to them after returning (Singh, 1965, p. 113). A trader's itinerary was thus connected to financial commitments as well as physical routes. The outward purchase and return sale formed parts of one arrangement. Commercial dependence could arise through credit even when the journey itself was undertaken by the borrower.

Lal Chand Negi's case gives this arrangement a seasonal and occupational setting. The survey describes his journeys during the 1940s, with departure in July and return to Kanum usually by November. He travelled with animals and employed shepherds, exchanging goods that included grain, cloth and utensils for products including wool and salt. After returning, merchandise was taken to Rampur (Singh, 1965, p. 114). This is evidence of an organised undertaking involving transport, labour and successive exchanges. The household trader was neither an isolated pedestrian carrying a surplus nor necessarily a merchant detached from agriculture.

Labour arrangements are especially significant here. The shepherds' remuneration included provisions and goods as well as money, according to the survey's description of Lal Chand's

caravan (Singh, 1965, p. 114). Their work made the trading journey possible, but their position differed from that of the person financing and directing it. Treating everyone travelling together as a single category of trader would conceal this difference. The circuit joined people through unequal responsibilities and returns, making the organisation of labour part of commodity history rather than a separate background issue.

Lavi at Rampur connected journeys of this kind with a concentrated market. The Census account places the fair in November and relates its timing to the descent of shepherds from higher pastures and the availability of wool for sale (Singh, 1964, p. 189). The fair's importance therefore involved a calendar as well as a location. It brought together participants whose movements and products became available at a particular point in the year. This seasonal concentration helps explain how dispersed production could support a substantial market without requiring producers to reside near a permanent trading centre.

The account of the fair observed on 11–13 November 1962 records wool and pashmina traders, livestock sellers, shops and smaller vendors. It also describes participants selling a few woollen articles to obtain household requirements and, in some cases, purchasing wool for further production (Singh, 1964, pp. 190–192). These activities connected different scales of exchange. The sale of a small household product and a merchant's larger consignment occurred within the same gathering, but served different purposes. The fair linked commercial distribution with household provisioning and the renewal of productive activity.

This evidence establishes a wider market setting for salt-linked trade without making every fair transaction a salt transaction. Kanum's survey connects imports from Tibet, including salt, with sales at Rampur; the fair account reveals the diversity of the market receiving such journeys. Read together, they support a history of intersecting commodity circuits. They do not establish that wool, grain and all other goods depended equally upon salt. That stronger proposition requires comparison of the connections sustained by different commodities, including the people and places they shared.

Lavi also brought information into circulation. The Nachar survey recalls seasonal migration and visits to the fair as occasions through which news from elsewhere reached the village (Singh, 1966, p. 54). Commercial journeys could therefore contribute to knowledge of conditions beyond the immediate locality. This observation gives the fair a significance extending beyond recorded purchases, while avoiding the assumption that every social encounter was economically motivated. Trade made meetings possible; the purposes and consequences of those meetings could exceed the transactions that initially brought people together.

The mid-century evidence also shows that circulation was being reorganised. In the Kanum revisit, Makhan Lal Negi's transition from Tibetan trade to a roadside eating house and shop began in 1959. His business benefited from road activity, but the subsequent shift of traffic towards a new alignment required another adjustment, including a new establishment near Spillo (Singh, 1965, pp. 113–114). A road did not simply increase access everywhere. It redistributed traffic between places, creating opportunities along one alignment while weakening establishments dependent on another.

Lal Chand's trajectory differed. He had left Tibetan trade in 1947 because he considered its returns inadequate for the effort involved, later entering panchayat employment. Padam Ram, by contrast, reported adverse effects from the closure of trade despite having other financial resources (Singh, 1965, p. 114). These cases resist a single chronology in which all traders prospered until an identical external shock forced them out. Withdrawal, diversification and continued dependence occurred at different times. The effect of disruption was mediated by land, capital, employment and earlier occupational decisions.

For commodity history, the implication is that declining trade and changing livelihoods must be examined together without treating them as interchangeable. A household might cease carrying Tibetan salt while remaining commercially active; a settlement might lose passing trade while gaining wage employment. The source material makes these changes visible through particular journeys and biographies. It also provides the context for examining regulation: market opportunities depended not only on goods and transport, but on political decisions concerning access, production and the terms of movement.

## 2.4 Commodity Regulation and Frontier Authority

Political authority entered salt circulation at several points. It could regulate entry into a territory, recognise exclusive trading privileges, supervise extraction or claim a share of revenue. These interventions did not necessarily belong to one institution. A trader might encounter different authorities while obtaining goods, crossing a pass and selling a consignment. Understanding the political economy of salt therefore requires attention to the location and object of each claim: control over production was different from authority over transit, and both differed from the power to determine an authorised price.

The Tingmosgang treaty provides an earlier example of commercial arrangements embedded in relations between authorities. Its reproduced clauses address wool privileges, recognised traders, tea and periodic missions (Peace Treaty between Ladakh and Tibet, 1684, clauses 2–5). Salt is not explicitly named in those clauses. The agreement is relevant here because it demonstrates the negotiated organisation of selected commodity movements, not because it can be used as direct evidence of a salt monopoly. It establishes a political context whose application to salt must be demonstrated separately.

Walton's account supplies that specificity for trade through Garhwal. Before traders from Niti entered Tibet, an official subordinate to the Jongpen investigated conditions concerning disease among people and animals and granted permission. Further licences allowed trade at additional marts (Walton, 1910, pp. 42–43). Admission was therefore more than passage across a physical threshold. It linked movement to inspection, payment and recognition by an authority. The existence of a route did not give every person an equivalent entitlement to use it or to trade at every destination.

The arrangements also varied among groups. Walton records differing obligations and permissions for traders associated with Niti and Mana, alongside privileges affecting competition in salt and wool (Walton, 1910, p. 43). This evidence makes exclusion part of the history of

commercial access. An established trader could benefit from restrictions imposed on a rival, even while bearing substantial charges personally. Regulation consequently cannot be interpreted only as an external burden on an otherwise undifferentiated trading population. It could distribute advantages unevenly within that population.

Licensing, monopoly and taxation should remain distinguishable in this account. A licence grants specified permission; a monopoly reserves an activity or market; a tax claims a payment. The mechanisms can interact, but one does not automatically establish the others. The Garhwal evidence also shows why regulation should not be described exclusively as a colonial innovation. Tibetan officials exercised authority within the exchanges recorded by a British gazetteer. The frontier economy involved overlapping political relationships, even when its description was organised from the perspective of a colonial district.

Mandi reveals a different connection between salt and government. Here the political question centred partly on production within the state and its relationship with British revenue interests. The gazetteer records the cancellation of a contractor’s arrangement on 1 July 1915, followed by direct state management of the quarries. It attributes the intervention to unsatisfactory working, including misuse of begar labour and delays in supplying traders (Emerson, 1920, p. 160). Problems at extraction thus affected circulation before a consignment left the production site. Administrative control of supply could influence a trader’s time and capacity to undertake further exchange.

The account associates the revised management with reopening Guman and reorganising work. It describes paid labour replacing the earlier begar arrangement for the work under discussion, while also recording the importance of preparing the sources during the rains (Emerson, 1920, p. 160). Seasonality operated at the quarry as well as on the mountain pass. The availability and organisation of labour during one period affected supply during another. Production history therefore adds a dimension that a route-centred account alone would miss: the conditions under which salt became available for transport.

The quarry establishment divided responsibilities among supervision, attendance, tools and weighing. Workers received bonuses linked to sales, while customary privileges and observances concerning the quarry goddesses continued (Emerson, 1920, p. 161). The arrangement combined administrative oversight with practices recognised locally. It cannot be reduced to a complete substitution of bureaucracy for custom. More revealing are the particular changes in who recorded work, who supervised it and how remuneration was organised. These details locate political and managerial authority within everyday production.

The gazetteer’s account of labour also contains a qualification to its reform narrative. Although it describes the abolition of begar in connection with quarry labour, later passages state that people removing salt in headloads were required to perform a day’s unpaid work (Emerson, 1920, pp. 160, 163–164). These were different obligations attached to different positions. Their coexistence means that a general statement about abolition cannot be extended automatically to every person encountering the salt establishment. Reading the administrative categories closely reveals the uneven scope of reform.

The fiscal history further connects Mandi production with British interests. In 1871 an additional duty was imposed, with receipts from salt destined for British territory assigned to the British government. Officials at the quarries registered consignment destinations to distribute the proceeds (Emerson, 1920, pp. 161–162). This arrangement made the intended movement of a commodity a basis for allocating revenue. The destination register was consequently an instrument of government as well as a potential historical source. What it recorded followed from the administrative purpose for which it was created.

Friction over that arrangement led to a revised division of duties introduced in 1880, while subsequent provisions linked Mandi's duty to the British rate and constrained reductions in its price without British sanction (Emerson, 1920, p. 162). The resulting authority was distributed rather than exercised through a simple transfer of ownership. The Raja retained an interest in production and receipts, while British fiscal policy shaped the terms under which salt could be sold. Such arrangements show how colonial influence could operate through agreements governing a commodity within a princely jurisdiction.

Twentieth-century changes in revenue arrangements did not end this relationship. The gazetteer records successive duty reductions in 1903, 1905 and 1907, followed by an increase in 1916 (Emerson, 1920, pp. 163–164). These revisions place the administration of salt within an ongoing fiscal history. They also caution against treating the tax burden as constant throughout the period covered by the source. For the present inquiry, the significant point is the continuing connection between the price encountered at production and decisions taken across more than one authority.

Later frontier restrictions altered a different set of relationships. The Kinnaur gazetteer attributes the ending of trade with Tibet to restrictions on transactions, currency difficulties and the non-renewal of the trade agreement. It also identifies the loss of access to Tibetan grazing grounds and describes attempts to redirect former traders towards other activities (Mamgain, 1971, pp. 184–185). The effects extended beyond the movement of merchandise. Pastoral access and the use of transport animals were implicated in the same political change, making the border consequential for several components of livelihood.

Ahmed's Rupshu account provides a regional contrast: border disruption was followed by local salt collection, while roads and subsidised supplies helped redirect earlier exchanges (Ahmed, 1999, p. 36). The comparison suggests that political closure can reorganise a commodity system without producing an identical outcome in every locality. A useful historical explanation must distinguish loss of access to a resource, reduced demand for a journey and the availability of alternative supplies. These processes can reinforce one another, but their timing and effects need to be established within the circuit concerned.

The fair account offers a contemporary indication of disruption. Its observers reported reduced attendance and trading activity at Lavi in November 1962, relating the subdued gathering to the border situation (Singh, 1964, p. 192). This is evidence of an affected market at a specified moment, rather than a complete measure of regional commercial contraction. Set beside the household histories, it shows political change operating at different scales: through the

conditions of a gathering, the viability of a journey and the choices available to individual traders.

Taken together, these cases locate authority in concrete arrangements governing movement, work and revenue. They also show why a single narrative of colonial regulation followed by postcolonial closure is insufficient. Commercial privileges could protect some traders, production reforms could retain unequal obligations, and new transport connections could redirect livelihoods after frontier exchanges contracted. Salt's political significance lay in these specific relationships, whose combination made control over a commodity consequential for activities extending beyond its immediate purchase and sale.

## 2.5 From Dispersed Sources to Historical Networks

The preceding discussion identifies connections that no single source records in full. A gazetteer describes the distribution of imports; a village survey identifies the trader, credit arrangement and onward market; a fair account records the gathering at which products changed hands. Bringing these observations together is necessary to investigate how commodity circuits operated beyond individual places. The problem is relational: the relevant evidence concerns connections among activities and participants that the documents describe separately.

A historical network provides a way to organise these connections for comparison. It can distinguish production from carriage, exchange from taxation, and a commercial partnership from a territorial claim. These distinctions follow from the history examined here. Combining all of them under a general category of association would lose the difference between a trader obtaining salt, an official charging a duty and a household receiving grain. The purpose of reconstruction is to make those relationships explicit while retaining the passages that establish them.

Several requirements follow from the documentary record. Names need to be identified across variant spellings, and the dates of reported activities must remain distinguishable from publication dates. A route described for one period should not be joined automatically to a later arrangement at the same place. Statements copied between publications also need to remain distinguishable from independent observations. These are conditions of historical comparison before they become questions of computational implementation.

The value of computation lies in assisting that comparison across a larger body of text. It can help organise references to commodities, places and institutions, bringing dispersed passages into a form that can be searched and examined together. Close reading remains necessary to establish what a connection means and whether the supporting passage warrants it. The resulting representation should allow the researcher to return from an apparent pattern to the evidence on which it rests.

For this thesis, the historical question concerns the extent to which salt connected activities also involving other commodities. The evidence assembled here identifies possible points of

connection, including shared transport, trading partners, seasonal markets and administrative arrangements. The next stage is to compare these relationships systematically, rather than infer structural importance from the frequency with which salt appears. Chapter 3 develops the conceptual and computational methodology for doing so, including Actor–Network Theory and the procedures for preparing, extracting and validating documentary relationships. Chapter 4 examines the resulting patterns and their historical interpretation.

## 2.6 Conclusion

The Western Himalayan salt economy was constituted through arrangements linking production, carriage, exchange and regulation. Seasonal journeys in Garhwal, trading households in Kanum, the gathering at Lavi and quarry administration in Mandi reveal different parts of that organisation. Their comparison shows how a commodity could connect livelihoods and jurisdictions while circulating alongside other goods. It also establishes substantial variation in access, obligations and the consequences of change.

The twentieth-century evidence makes that variation particularly clear. Alternative supplies, road alignments, occupational decisions and frontier restrictions altered circuits through distinct mechanisms. A decline in one form of trade did not necessarily end commercial activity, while the persistence of salt collection did not imply continuity in its earlier routes. Historical explanation therefore requires attention to the relationships that changed and to the people differently positioned within them.

These findings provide the documentary foundation for the next chapter. The transition to computational reconstruction follows from the need to compare dispersed, dated relationships across sources. Its contribution will depend on preserving the historical distinctions established here while making the wider organisation of the evidence available for analysis.